

MUMBAI MEETS CHENNAI

Southern content meets northern cash as corporates invest in Tamil, Telugu and Kannada films and stars

■ By Kaverie Bamzai

There was a time Boney Kapoor would be the only northern producer studying southern film box-office returns for possible remakes. Sixteen of the 31 films he has produced in his career have been remakes of southern films—in addition to several films he has sourced for his brother, actor Anil, among them some of his biggest hits such as *Beta* and *Virasat*. But now he has company. Every major Mumbai star is currently acting in a major remake. Aamir Khan has just wrapped up *Ghajini*, directed by the same man who steered Surya through the Tamil version (which is loosely adapted from Christopher Nolan's arthouse hit *Memento*). Shah Rukh Khan is waiting to shoot two songs for closure on *Billoo Barber*, adapted from *Katha Parayumbol* in Malayalam, and seen as *Kuselan* in Tamil, starring Rajnikant. Salman Khan has just three

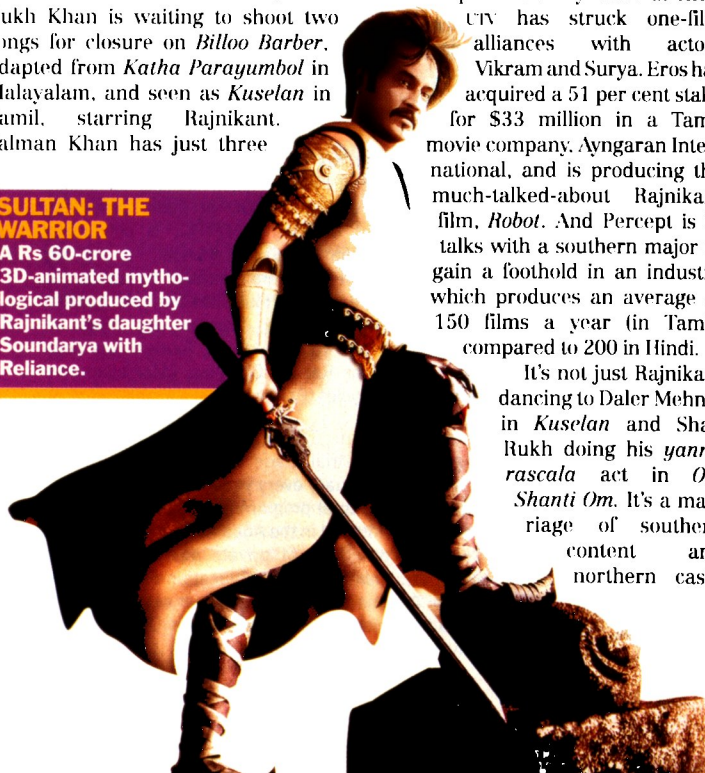
songs to go before the remake of *Pokkiri*, called *Wanted: Dead And Alive*, ends (purchased by Boney from the producers of the original in Telugu starring Mahesh Babu and directed by Prabhudeva). Even *Punjab da puttari* Akshay Kumar has acted in *Bhool Bhulaiyya*, adapted by Priyadarshan from *Manichithrathazhu* which lent itself to the Tamil version, *Chandramukhi*.

That's not all. Mumbai's corporates, in their desire to become as Priyadarshan says, "pan-Indian", have discovered that acquisitions in the south give them scale and content. Reliance is spending close to Rs 200 crore on making films in the south, part of what Reliance Entertainment Chairman Amit Khanna calls its strategy to be present everywhere at once.

UTV has struck one-film alliances with actors Vikram and Surya. Eros has acquired a 51 per cent stake for \$33 million in a Tamil movie company, Aayngaran International, and is producing the much-talked-about Rajnikant film, *Robot*. And Percept is in talks with a southern major to gain a foothold in an industry which produces an average of 150 films a year (in Tamil) compared to 200 in Hindi.

It's not just Rajnikant dancing to Daler Mehndi in *Kuselan* and Shah Rukh doing his *yanna rascala* act in *Om Shanti Om*. It's a marriage of southern content and northern cash.

SULTAN: THE WARRIOR
A Rs 60-crore 3D-animated mythological produced by Rajnikant's daughter Soundarya with Reliance.



It's also a marriage of convenience. There are only so many foreign language films that Bollywood can rip off and with Hollywood production houses setting up base in India, it's getting difficult to steal stories from them without paying copyright fees. Instead, films from down south are less expensive (though Boney has just paid Rs 1 crore for the remake rights of the Telugu hit, *Bommarilu*, being made in Hindi as *It's My Life*, and already remade in Tamil as *Santosh Subramaniam*). They also come with their own band of super-